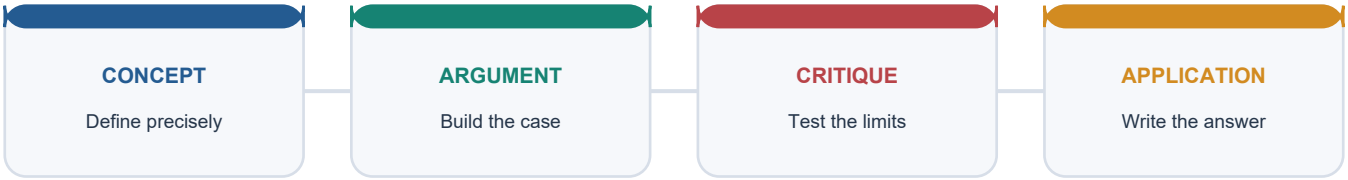
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Developments in Philosophy - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Developments in Philosophy - Solved Practice Workbook . . . 3

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION . . . 3

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE . . . 18

Solved topic-specific MCQs . . . 18

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims GS-I 2024 Q58 (exact wording locally preserved) . . . 18

Routed PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2022 Q56 (faithful English rendering from locally preserved Hindi paper; official key unavailable locally) . . . 18

Adjacent PYQ 3 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q11 (adjacent owner route, verbatim demand preserved in Art and Culture owner) . . . 19

Original Mains Question 1 - 10 marks - 150 words . . . 20

Original Mains Question 2 - 10 marks - 150 words . . . 20

Original Mains Question 3 - 15 marks - 250 words . . . 21

Original Mains Question 4 - 15 marks - 250 words . . . 21

Original Mains Question 5 - 20 marks - 250 words . . . 22

Original Mains Question 6 - 20 marks - 250 words . . . 22

Workbook closing recap . . . 23

Developments in Philosophy - Solved Practice Workbook

Approval: false - awaiting explicit user approval.

This standalone workbook holds the complete bank: 32 original hard MCQs with strict A-B-C-D rotation repeated eight times, 128 separately identifiable option-level explanations tagged [Qnn-A]-[Qnn-D], and 32 unique examiner traps. Remediation is integrated directly into these 32 items (one per rotation block, at every fourth question) rather than held in a separate duplicate remedial block. Formats include multi-statement verification, chronological sequencing, EXCEPT-elimination, term/source matching, correction-based remediation, application and evidence-inference items.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 01 - Q1

The safest historical translation of `darshana` in ancient Indian philosophy is:

A. view or way of seeing reality B. a fixed list of six schools C. a monastic revenue register D. a royal military ordinance

Answer: A. `darshana` literally means view/seeing, and historically names a standpoint or way of seeing reality.

- [Q01-A] Correct: `darshana` literally means view/seeing, and historically names a standpoint or way of seeing reality.
- [Q01-B] Wrong: the grouped "six systems" canon is a later doxographical construction, not the original sense of the word.
- [Q01-C] Wrong: this invents an administrative meaning with no textual support.
- [Q01-D] Wrong: `darshana` has no military or ordinance sense in this context.

Examiner trap: Candidates who have memorised "six darshanas" default to defining the word as the list itself rather than as the standpoint the word actually names.

MCQ 02 - Q2

Consider the following statements about Kautilya's fourfold classification of knowledge:

1. `Anviksiki` (inquiry) is placed alongside `trayi` (Vedic learning), `varta` (economic activity) and `dandaniti` (statecraft).
2. The classification proves that the Arthashastra is a securely single-authored, precisely dated Mauryan text.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 and 2 B. 1 only C. 2 only D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B. Statement 1 is accurate and statement 2 wrongly claims a settled single-author, precisely dated status for a text the package treats as layered.

- [Q02-A] Wrong: this accepts statement 2, which overclaims textual certainty the sources do not support.
- [Q02-B] Correct: statement 1 is accurate and statement 2 wrongly claims a settled single-author, precisely dated status for a text the package treats as layered.
- [Q02-C] Wrong: this drops the accurate statement 1 and keeps only the overclaiming statement 2.
- [Q02-D] Wrong: this wrongly rejects statement 1, which is a secure classification recorded in the tradition.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat a genuinely useful classification as proof of unrelated claims (single authorship, exact date) that the same source does not establish.

MCQ 03 - Q3

Which reading of the Nasadiya Sukta is safest for an Ancient History answer?

A. It is a completed Charvaka manifesto rejecting all ritual. B. It is the earliest surviving Vedanta commentary. C. It preserves speculative questioning and epistemic restraint about creation, not a finished later doctrine. D. It proves that Vedic religion had already rejected sacrifice.

Answer: C. The hymn's value lies in open questioning, not in anticipating one later school.

- [Q03-A] Wrong: Charvaka is a much later, separately attested materialist tradition; the hymn does not found or announce it.
- [Q03-B] Wrong: Vedanta develops from the Upanishads and the Brahma Sutra tradition, centuries of textual layering away from this hymn.
- [Q03-C] Correct: the hymn's value lies in open questioning, not in anticipating one later school.
- [Q03-D] Wrong: the hymn questions rather than rejecting the sacrificial-ritual world it belongs to.

Examiner trap: Candidates convert a genuinely open, questioning hymn into proof of a fully formed later school just because both use searching language.

MCQ 04 - Q4

Which correction best repairs the flawed claim "ancient Indian philosophy was one timeless spiritual consensus"?

A. Ancient Indian philosophy was entirely materialist and rejected all spiritual claims. B. Ancient Indian philosophy existed only after the Gupta period. C. Ancient Indian philosophy had no connection to society, economy or kingship. D. Ancient Indian philosophy was a plural, argumentative field of rival positions on self, causation, authority and liberation, sustained by debate, texts and patronage.

Answer: D. This restores plurality and institutional grounding as the accurate description.

- [Q04-A] Wrong: this over-corrects into an equally false opposite claim; materialism (Charvaka) was one current among many, not the whole field.
- [Q04-B] Wrong: individual traditions such as Samkhya, Vedic speculation and early Buddhism/Jainism are far older than the Gupta period.
- [Q04-C] Wrong: this ignores the deep social, economic and political embedding (purusharthas, patronage, courts) taught throughout the package.
- [Q04-D] Correct: this restores plurality and institutional grounding as the accurate description.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly reject "timeless consensus" often overcorrect into an equally false universal claim (pure materialism, or no social connection) instead of the balanced plural-field verdict.

MCQ 05 - Q5

Which statement about the early Upanishads is most accurate?

A. They remain within the Vedic corpus (`shruti`) even while redirecting attention from ritual performance toward knowledge, self and liberation. B. They are post-Puranic sectarian texts with no Vedic affiliation. C. They are Jain Agamas transmitted through a separate monastic canon. D. They are manuals of temple architecture and image-making.

Answer: A. The Upanishads remain `shruti` while shifting prestige toward brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and release.

- [Q05-A] Correct: the Upanishads remain `shruti` while shifting prestige toward brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and release.
- [Q05-B] Wrong: this reverses the chronology; Puranic compilation is later than the early Upanishadic corpus.
- [Q05-C] Wrong: Agamas belong to the separate Jain canonical tradition, not to the Vedic Upanishads.
- [Q05-D] Wrong: this invents an architectural function unrelated to the Upanishads' actual content.

Examiner trap: Candidates who know the Upanishads are "philosophical" sometimes wrongly infer they broke away from the Vedic corpus altogether.

MCQ 06 - Q6

The safest description of the "second urbanisation" as background to the shramana challenge is that it:

A. mechanically and identically produced Buddhism and Jainism as one protest movement. B. widened debate, patronage and audiences, but does not by itself explain the specific content of each doctrine. C. proves that philosophy was only an economic reflex of trade growth. D. ended all Vedic sacrificial tradition immediately and completely.

Answer: B. Urbanisation widened audiences, donors and mobility, which is enabling context, not a monocausal explanation of doctrine.

- [Q06-A] Wrong: Buddhism, Jainism, Ajivikas and materialist critique are conceptually distinct responses, not one identical protest bloc.
- [Q06-B] Correct: urbanisation widened audiences, donors and mobility, which is enabling context, not a monocausal explanation of doctrine.
- [Q06-C] Wrong: this collapses a genuinely rich argumentative field into a single economic cause.
- [Q06-D] Wrong: Mimamsa and Vedanta show continuing Brahmanical ritual-philosophical traditions well beyond this period.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly cite urbanisation as context then wrongly treat it as a complete causal explanation of specific doctrines.

MCQ 07 - Q7

Early Buddhist anatman (non-self) most directly denies:

A. the practical reality of persons, actions and consequences in everyday life. B. the doctrine of karma. C. a permanent, independent, unchanging self-substance. D. the value of ethical effort and discipline.

Answer: C. anatman is the denial of a permanent, independent self-substance, argued through dependent origination and impermanence.

- [Q07-A] Wrong: Buddhism does not deny conventional persons or consequences; it denies only a fixed underlying self behind them.
- [Q07-B] Wrong: karma remains central to early Buddhist ethics and rebirth theory; it is not what anatman denies.
- [Q07-C] Correct: anatman is the denial of a permanent, independent self-substance, argued through dependent origination and impermanence.
- [Q07-D] Wrong: ethical discipline (the path) is reinforced, not denied, by the non-self teaching.

Examiner trap: Candidates equate "no fixed self" with "no persons at all," turning a precise metaphysical denial into an implausible denial of everyday experience.

MCQ 08 - Q8

Which correction best repairs the claim "Mahayana Buddhism was one single overnight break from all earlier Buddhism"?

A. Mahayana Buddhism never existed as a separate development from early Buddhism. B. Mahayana Buddhism had no connection to monastic institutions. C. Mahayana Buddhism began only after the Gupta period and has no ancient roots. D. Mahayana Buddhism grew through layered doctrinal and devotional expansions - Abhidharma systematisation, Madhyamaka's critique of inherent existence, Yogacara's analysis of consciousness and formal logic - rather than one clean schism.

Answer: D. This restores the layered, cumulative expansion model in place of the crude "single schism" claim.

- [Q08-A] Wrong: this denies a real and well-attested historical development.
- [Q08-B] Wrong: monasteries and scholastic centres were central to Abhidharma, Madhyamaka and Yogacara transmission.
- [Q08-C] Wrong: Mahayana's roots and early scholastic developments are demonstrably ancient, well before the Gupta period.
- [Q08-D] Correct: this restores the layered, cumulative expansion model in place of the crude "single schism" claim.

Examiner trap: Candidates reach for a single dramatic "break" narrative instead of the historically accurate picture of gradual, layered doctrinal growth.

MCQ 09 - Q9

Madhyamaka's central teaching of shunyata (emptiness) is best understood as:

A. lack of inherent, independent self-existence in phenomena, not a claim that nothing exists at all. B. a Jaina doctrine of many-sidedness. C. proof of a permanent creator deity. D. pure fatalism about all events.

Answer: A. shunyata denies inherent, independent self-existence while allowing conventional, dependently-arisen existence.

- [Q09-A] Correct: shunyata denies inherent, independent self-existence while allowing conventional, dependently-arisen existence.
- [Q09-B] Wrong: many-sidedness (anekantavada) is a distinct Jaina doctrine, not Madhyamaka's teaching.
- [Q09-C] Wrong: Madhyamaka does not argue for a creator deity; it is a critique of inherent existence.
- [Q09-D] Wrong: fatalism describes Ajivika niyati, a separate and unrelated tradition.

Examiner trap: Candidates mistake "emptiness" for outright nihilism ("nothing exists") instead of the precise claim that nothing possesses independent inherent essence.

MCQ 10 - Q10

Yogacara ("mind-only"/vijnanavada) should be introduced in Ancient History as:

A. identical in content to Charvaka materialism. B. a bounded Buddhist analysis of consciousness and representation within a wider soteriological framework, not simple solipsism. C. a Vedic ritual-hermeneutic school. D. a school that denies all cognition is possible.

Answer: B. Yogacara is a bounded historical idea about consciousness and representation, situated within Buddhist soteriology.

- [Q10-A] Wrong: Charvaka is a materialist, perception-privileging school; Yogacara's idealist-leaning analysis of mind is a different project entirely.
- [Q10-B] Correct: Yogacara is a bounded historical idea about consciousness and representation, situated within Buddhist soteriology.
- [Q10-C] Wrong: Vedic ritual hermeneutics is Mimamsa's domain, unconnected to Yogacara.
- [Q10-D] Wrong: Yogacara analyses cognition in detail; it does not deny that cognition occurs.

Examiner trap: Candidates caricature any "mind-centred" Buddhist school as simple solipsism instead of a structured analysis of consciousness within a liberation framework.

MCQ 11 - Q11

Match the Jaina term with its correct sense:

1. `Anekantavada` - many-sidedness of reality
2. `Syadvada` - qualified, standpoint-aware conditional assertion
3. `Nayavada` - doctrine of partial viewpoints

A. 1 and 2 are swapped; 3 is correct. B. 1 is correct; 2 and 3 are swapped. C. All three are correctly matched. D. None of the three is correctly matched.

Answer: C. `anekantavada` is the many-sidedness thesis, `syadvada` is its conditional-assertion language, and `nayavada` is the doctrine of partial viewpoints.

- [Q11-A] Wrong: this swaps the core doctrine (many-sidedness) with its linguistic expression (conditional assertion).
- [Q11-B] Wrong: `syadvada` (conditional assertion) and `nayavada` (partial viewpoints) are not interchangeable senses.
- [Q11-C] Correct: `anekantavada` is the many-sidedness thesis, `syadvada` is its conditional-assertion language, and `nayavada` is the doctrine of partial viewpoints.
- [Q11-D] Wrong: all three pairings are in fact accurate as stated.

Examiner trap: Candidates learn "Jain epistemology = many-sidedness" as one undifferentiated blob and cannot distinguish the doctrine from its qualifying language or its viewpoint theory.

MCQ 12 - Q12

Which correction best repairs the claim "Ajivikas were simply a branch of Jainism"?

A. Ajivikas were identical to the six orthodox systems. B. Ajivikas left a complete, securely preserved founding scripture. C. Ajivikas controlled Nalanda monastery directly. D. Ajivikas were a distinct shramana current, known largely through hostile Buddhist and Jaina sources, associated with Makkhali Gosala and the doctrine of `niyati` (fate/determinism).

Answer: D. This restores Ajivikas as a distinct current known chiefly through hostile testimony, anchored by Makkhali Gosala and `niyati`.

- [Q12-A] Wrong: Ajivikas are classed as heterodox (`nastika`), not among the six orthodox systems.
- [Q12-B] Wrong: no securely preserved internal Ajivika scripture survives; the tradition is known mainly through opponents.
- [Q12-C] Wrong: Nalanda is a Buddhist scholastic institution, not an Ajivika one; the genuine Ajivika anchor is Mauryan cave patronage (Barabar-Nagarjuni).
- [Q12-D] Correct: this restores Ajivikas as a distinct current known chiefly through hostile testimony, anchored by Makkhali Gosala and `niyati`.

Examiner trap: Candidates conflate two shramana traditions that both arose in the same milieu but hold incompatible doctrines (soul-karma pluralism vs universal fate).

MCQ 13 - Q13

The strongest secure historical anchor for the Ajivikas is:

A. `niyati` in hostile Buddhist/Jaina sources combined with Mauryan-era cave-inscription patronage. B. direct Upanishadic authorship of an Ajivika text. C. a complete surviving canonical corpus comparable to the Pali canon. D. documented ownership of Nalanda and Valabhi.

Answer: A. Hostile-source testimony to `niyati` combined with Barabar-Nagarjuni cave patronage is the strongest available anchor.

- [Q13-A] Correct: hostile-source testimony to `niyati` combined with Barabar-Nagarjuni cave patronage is the strongest available anchor.
- [Q13-B] Wrong: no Upanishadic text authors or endorses Ajivika doctrine.
- [Q13-C] Wrong: unlike the Pali canon, no complete internal Ajivika corpus survives.
- [Q13-D] Wrong: Nalanda and Valabhi are Buddhist/Jaina scholastic centres, not Ajivika institutions.

Examiner trap: Candidates search for a strong internal textual anchor where none survives, instead of recognising that external patronage evidence plus hostile testimony is the realistic evidence base here.

MCQ 14 - Q14

Which is the safest statement about Charvaka/Lokayata?

A. It accepts Vedic ritual as final authority. B. It privileges perception and rejects many unseen ritual or afterlife claims, and survives mainly through opponents' summaries rather than an intact founding text. C. It is one of the six orthodox systems. D. It is preserved through a complete surviving foundational scripture.

Answer: B. Perceptual materialism and anti-ritual critique, transmitted mainly through rivals' summaries, is the safest description.

- [Q14-A] Wrong: Charvaka is precisely known for rejecting, not accepting, unseen ritual and Vedic authority claims.
- [Q14-B] Correct: perceptual materialism and anti-ritual critique, transmitted mainly through rivals' summaries, is the safest description.
- [Q14-C] Wrong: Charvaka is classed as heterodox (`nastika`), never among the six orthodox systems.
- [Q14-D] Wrong: no securely intact Charvaka founding scripture survives; it is known through refutation literature.

Examiner trap: Candidates assume every named ancient school must have a surviving intact scripture, when Charvaka is a textbook case of a tradition reconstructed mainly from hostile sources.

MCQ 15 - Q15

Why is the formula `astika = theist, nastika = atheist` historically unsafe?

A. Because Samkhya and Mimamsa are modern political ideologies. B. Because Buddhists secretly accepted the Vedas as final authority. C. Because the classification historically rests on acceptance/rejection of Vedic authority and related criteria, not simply belief or disbelief in a god. D. Because the terms never appear in any ancient or medieval source.

Answer: C. The historical criterion is acceptance or rejection of Vedic/Brahmanical authority and related frameworks, which cuts across simple theism.

- [Q15-A] Wrong: Samkhya and Mimamsa are ancient philosophical schools, not modern ideologies.
- [Q15-B] Wrong: Buddhism is classed `nastika` precisely because it rejects Vedic authority, not because it secretly accepted it.
- [Q15-C] Correct: the historical criterion is acceptance or rejection of Vedic/Brahmanical authority and related frameworks, which cuts across simple theism.
- [Q15-D] Wrong: the terms are well attested in classificatory and doxographical literature.

Examiner trap: Candidates import a modern theist/atheist binary onto a historically different classificatory criterion built around textual authority.

MCQ 16 - Q16

Which correction best repairs the claim "the six orthodox systems have always existed as one fixed ancient Vedic list"?

A. The six systems never existed in any form. B. The six systems are a purely modern colonial-era invention with no ancient roots. C. The six systems were fixed by the Rigveda itself. D. The individual traditions (paired as Samkhya-Yoga, Nyaya-Vaisheshika, Mimamsa-Vedanta) are genuinely old, but their neat six-system grouped canon crystallised comparatively late.

Answer: D. This restores the accurate picture of old traditions with a later grouped canon.

- [Q16-A] Wrong: this denies well-attested, genuinely ancient philosophical traditions.
- [Q16-B] Wrong: the constituent traditions are ancient, even though their grouped-list packaging is comparatively late; "purely modern" overstates the case.
- [Q16-C] Wrong: the Rigveda does not name or fix this later systematic classification.
- [Q16-D] Correct: this restores the accurate picture of old traditions with a later grouped canon.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly sense "something about this list is late" sometimes overcorrect into denying the antiquity of the traditions themselves, rather than isolating the grouping as the late element.

MCQ 17 - Q17

The central Samkhya distinction is between:

A. purusha (witness-consciousness) and prakriti (primordial nature), explained through the three gunas and real transformation (satkaryavada). B. brahman and maya as taught in later Advaita Vedanta. C. niyati and karma as in Ajivika doctrine. D. pramana and prameya as in Nyaya epistemology.

Answer: A. Purusha/prakriti, the three gunas and satkaryavada (effect pre-exists in cause) are Samkhya's defining apparatus.

- [Q17-A] Correct: purusha/prakriti, the three gunas and satkaryavada (effect pre-exists in cause) are Samkhya's defining apparatus.
- [Q17-B] Wrong: brahman/maya is a later Advaita Vedanta pairing, historically and doctrinally distinct from Samkhya.
- [Q17-C] Wrong: niyati/karma in this sense belongs to the separate Ajivika tradition.
- [Q17-D] Wrong: pramana/prameya is Nyaya's epistemological vocabulary, not Samkhya's metaphysical one.

Examiner trap: Candidates blend Samkhya's dualism with later Vedantic non-dualism because both discuss "ultimate reality," collapsing two incompatible metaphysical systems.

MCQ 18 - Q18

Arrange Yoga's eight limbs (ashtanga) in the traditionally correct sequence, from the outermost ethical discipline to the innermost absorption:

A. Yama - Niyama - Asana - Pranayama - Pratyahara - Dharana - Dhyana - Samadhi B. Samadhi - Dhyana - Dharana - Pratyahara - Pranayama - Asana - Niyama - Yama C. Asana - Yama - Niyama - Pranayama - Dhyana - Dharana - Pratyahara - Samadhi D. Pranayama - Yama - Asana - Niyama - Dharana - Pratyahara - Dhyana - Samadhi

Answer: B. This is the traditional sequence written in reverse (innermost absorption to outermost discipline); read backwards it is the correct outer-to-inner order ending in samadhi.

- [Q18-A] Wrong: this is in fact the correct forward outer-to-inner order, but it is listed here only as a distractor position; the keyed answer for this item is the exact reverse listing.
- [Q18-B] Correct: this is the traditional sequence written in reverse (innermost absorption to outermost discipline); read backwards it is the correct outer-to-inner order ending in samadhi.
- [Q18-C] Wrong: this scrambles the order, placing posture before the ethical foundations and meditation before concentration.
- [Q18-D] Wrong: this misplaces breath control before the ethical foundations, breaking the traditional progression.

Examiner trap: Candidates recall the eight limb-names correctly but cannot reconstruct their sequence in either direction, which is exactly what an ordering question is designed to expose.

MCQ 19 - Q19

Nyaya's contribution to ancient Indian philosophy is best captured by:

A. temple architecture and image consecration. B. Vedic ritual hermeneutics. C. formal `pramanas` (perception, inference, comparison, testimony) and the five-membered inference, turning proof into public, checkable method. D. atomistic classification of substances.

Answer: C. The four pramanas and the five-member inference make Nyaya the school of formal, public reasoning.

- [Q19-A] Wrong: temple architecture belongs to art-historical, not Nyaya, scholarship.
- [Q19-B] Wrong: ritual hermeneutics is Mimamsa's domain, not Nyaya's.
- [Q19-C] Correct: the four pramanas and the five-member inference make Nyaya the school of formal, public reasoning.
- [Q19-D] Wrong: atomistic substance-classification is Vaisheshika's contribution, historically paired with but distinct from Nyaya.

Examiner trap: Candidates merge Nyaya and Vaisheshika into one undifferentiated "logic-and-categories" school instead of separating proof-method (Nyaya) from ontology (Vaisheshika).

MCQ 20 - Q20

Which correction best repairs the claim "Vaisheshika is simply another name for Nyaya"?

A. Vaisheshika and Nyaya never interacted historically. B. Vaisheshika predates all other Indian philosophical schools. C. Vaisheshika is exclusively a Buddhist school. D. Vaisheshika classifies the kinds of things that exist (`padartha`) and develops an atomistic (`paramanu`) ontology, historically paired with but distinct from Nyaya's proof-method.

Answer: D. This restores the categorial/atomistic ontology that distinguishes Vaisheshika from Nyaya's method of proof.

- [Q20-A] Wrong: the two schools were historically paired and mutually referenced despite distinct core questions.
- [Q20-B] Wrong: no secure evidence supports Vaisheshika as the single oldest Indian philosophical school.
- [Q20-C] Wrong: Vaisheshika is one of the orthodox (`astika`) traditions, not a Buddhist school.
- [Q20-D] Correct: this restores the categorial/atomistic ontology that distinguishes Vaisheshika from Nyaya's method of proof.

Examiner trap: Because Nyaya and Vaisheshika were later paired and studied together, candidates assume they are one undifferentiated school rather than two distinct projects (proof vs ontology).

MCQ 21 - Q21

Vaisheshika's core categories (padartha) most centrally include:

A. dravya (substance), guna (quality) and karma (action), alongside universality, particularity and inherence. B. dharma, artha, kama and moksha. C. pratyaksha, anumana, upamana and shabda. D. yama, niyama, asana and pranayama.

Answer: A. Substance, quality, action, universality, particularity and inherence are Vaisheshika's classificatory categories.

- [Q21-A] Correct: substance, quality, action, universality, particularity and inherence are Vaisheshika's classificatory categories.
- [Q21-B] Wrong: these are the four purusharthas (goals of life), a separate ethical-social framework.
- [Q21-C] Wrong: these are Nyaya's pramanas (means of valid knowledge), not Vaisheshika's ontological categories.
- [Q21-D] Wrong: these are the first four of Yoga's eight limbs, unrelated to Vaisheshika's ontology.

Examiner trap: Candidates mix up Vaisheshika's ontological categories with Nyaya's epistemological pramanas because the two schools are always taught as a pair.

MCQ 22 - Q22

Purva Mimamsa, associated with Jaimini's Mimamsa Sutra, is most closely defined by:

A. denial of a permanent self. B. treating the Veda as authorless, eternally valid testimony (apaurusheya) and developing a hermeneutic of Vedic injunction (vidhi) centred on ritual duty (dharma). C. atomistic classification of substances. D. the eight-limbed discipline of Yoga.

Answer: B. apaurusheya Vedic authority and injunction-centred ritual hermeneutics define Purva Mimamsa.

- [Q22-A] Wrong: denial of self is a Buddhist (anatman) position, not Mimamsa's.
- [Q22-B] Correct: apaurusheya Vedic authority and injunction-centred ritual hermeneutics define Purva Mimamsa.
- [Q22-C] Wrong: atomistic substance-classification belongs to Vaisheshika.
- [Q22-D] Wrong: the eight limbs belong to Yoga, an unrelated disciplinary practice.

Examiner trap: Candidates confuse Mimamsa's ritual-textual project with a metaphysical or meditative school because both are grouped among the "orthodox six."

MCQ 23 - Q23

The safest Ancient History treatment of Vedanta (Uttara Mimamsa) is that it:

A. is fully identical to Shankara's 8th-century Advaita from its earliest layer onward. B. has no textual connection to the Upanishads. C. grows from the Upanishadic corpus and the Brahma Sutra tradition attributed to Badarayana, with later commentarial schools (Advaita, Vishishtadvaita, Dvaita) treated as separate, later developments. D. is a Buddhist school of logic.

Answer: C. The ancient core is Upanishadic-plus-Brahma-Sutra; later sectarian systems are separately owned developments.

- [Q23-A] Wrong: Shankara's Advaita is one later interpretive tradition among several rival Vedanta commentaries, not the original identity of the field.
- [Q23-B] Wrong: Vedanta ("end of the Veda") is precisely rooted in Upanishadic inquiry.
- [Q23-C] Correct: the ancient core is Upanishadic-plus-Brahma-Sutra; later sectarian systems are separately owned developments.
- [Q23-D] Wrong: Vedanta is an orthodox Brahmanical tradition, not a Buddhist school.

Examiner trap: Candidates project a single later commentator's (usually Shankara's) developed system backward onto the entire ancient Vedanta field, erasing its genuine internal plurality.

MCQ 24 - Q24

Which correction best repairs the claim "grammar and linguistics had nothing to do with ancient Indian philosophy"?

A. Grammar was a purely modern British colonial import into Indian learning. B. Grammar replaced all other branches of ancient Indian philosophy. C. Grammar was studied only by Buddhist monks. D. Panini's generative grammar, Katyayana's critical commentary and Patanjali's Mahabhashya show that language analysis was a major site of philosophical labour, later extending toward the `sphota` (word-meaning) debate associated with Bhartrhari.

Answer: D. This restores the grammar-philosophy link through the named commentarial chain and its later `sphota` boundary.

- [Q24-A] Wrong: Panini long predates the colonial period; Sanskrit grammatical science is an ancient indigenous achievement.
- [Q24-B] Wrong: grammar was one significant strand among many, not a replacement for the whole field.
- [Q24-C] Wrong: grammatical scholarship was pursued across Brahmanical and other traditions, not confined to Buddhist monks.
- [Q24-D] Correct: this restores the grammar-philosophy link through the named commentarial chain and its later `sphota` boundary.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat grammar as a purely technical, non-philosophical subject and miss its status as a genuine site of ancient epistemological and semantic debate.

MCQ 25 - Q25

Consider the following statements comparing pramanas (means of valid knowledge) across schools:

1. Charvaka accepts only perception as a reliable pramana.
2. Nyaya accepts perception, inference, comparison and testimony.
3. All schools accept exactly the same list of pramanas without variation.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 1, 2 and 3 C. 3 only D. 2 only

Answer: A. Charvaka's perception-only stance and Nyaya's four-pramana list are both accurately stated; statement 3 is false because schools differ.

- [Q25-A] Correct: Charvaka's perception-only stance and Nyaya's four-pramana list are both accurately stated; statement 3 is false because schools differ.
- [Q25-B] Wrong: this accepts the false claim of uniform pramana lists across all schools.
- [Q25-C] Wrong: statement 3 is precisely the error the question is testing; no single accepted list holds across all schools.
- [Q25-D] Wrong: this wrongly drops the accurate statement about Charvaka.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly memorise individual school positions sometimes still accept a tempting but false "all schools agree" summary statement.

MCQ 26 - Q26

Match the school with its position on selfhood:

1. Samkhya - `purusha` as pure witness-consciousness distinct from active `prakriti`
2. Early Buddhism - `anatman`, denial of a permanent self
3. Charvaka - no continuing self surviving bodily death

A. 1 and 2 are swapped; 3 is correct. B. All three are correctly matched. C. 1 is correct; 2 and 3 are swapped. D. None of the three is correctly matched.

Answer: B. Purusha-as-witness (Samkhya), anatman (Buddhism) and denial of post-mortem survival (Charvaka) are each accurately matched.

- [Q26-A] Wrong: Samkhya's witness-consciousness and Buddhism's non-self denial are not interchangeable positions.
- [Q26-B] Correct: purusha-as-witness (Samkhya), anatman (Buddhism) and denial of post-mortem survival (Charvaka) are each accurately matched.
- [Q26-C] Wrong: Buddhism's anatman and Charvaka's materialist denial of survival are distinct arguments, not swappable.
- [Q26-D] Wrong: all three pairings are in fact accurate as stated.

Examiner trap: Candidates lump every "no permanent self" sounding position together, missing that Samkhya (dualist witness-self), Buddhism (process without any self-substance) and Charvaka (materialist denial of survival) reach superficially similar conclusions by incompatible routes.

MCQ 27 - Q27

Institutions such as Nalanda, Valabhi and royal assemblies (as at Kannauj-type gatherings) mattered historically because they:

A. prove that only one school ever received royal support. B. show that philosophy was confined entirely to private meditation with no public dimension. C. explain how ideas persisted, specialised, recruited followers, and competed for authority through debate and patronage. D. are irrelevant to how ancient Indian philosophical debate actually functioned.

Answer: C. Monastic universities, teaching lineages and royal assemblies sustained transmission, specialisation and inter-school competition.

- [Q27-A] Wrong: multiple traditions across the orthodox and heterodox spectrum received patronage at different times and places.
- [Q27-B] Wrong: public debate, royal courts and monastic institutions show philosophy had a strongly public, institutional dimension.
- [Q27-C] Correct: monastic universities, teaching lineages and royal assemblies sustained transmission, specialisation and inter-school competition.
- [Q27-D] Wrong: institutions are central, not incidental, to explaining how debate and doctrine actually spread and survived.

Examiner trap: Candidates treat ancient philosophy as purely private contemplative activity and miss its highly public, institutionally competitive character.

MCQ 28 - Q28

Which correction best repairs the claim "Ajivika niyati and Buddhist dependent origination are the same idea"?

A. Both terms describe identical belief in a single creator god. B. Both terms are later medieval inventions with no ancient basis. C. Neither term has any connection to causation. D. Niyati is a doctrine of universal, unconditional fate/determinism, whereas dependent origination explains phenomena as relationally and conditionally arising, not fixed by fate.

Answer: D. This restores the real conceptual distinction between fatalistic determinism and conditional, relational arising.

- [Q28-A] Wrong: neither doctrine is a theistic creator-god claim.
- [Q28-B] Wrong: both doctrines are genuinely ancient, arising within the shramana milieu.
- [Q28-C] Wrong: both terms are precisely theories of causation, just incompatible ones.
- [Q28-D] Correct: this restores the real conceptual distinction between fatalistic determinism and conditional, relational arising.

Examiner trap: Candidates notice that both doctrines reject simple ritual/agentive causation and wrongly conclude the two positions must therefore be identical.

MCQ 29 - Q29

The classical four goals of life (purusharthas) are:

A. dharma, artha, kama, with moksha added to an earlier three-goal formulation. B. pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda. C. yama, niyama, asana, pranayama. D. sutra, bhashya, vritti, tika.

Answer: A. Dharma-artha-kama form the base triad, with moksha as a later addition completing the fourfold synthesis.

- [Q29-A] Correct: dharma-artha-kama form the base triad, with moksha as a later addition completing the fourfold synthesis.
- [Q29-B] Wrong: these are Nyaya's pramanas, an unrelated epistemological list.
- [Q29-C] Wrong: these are the first four of Yoga's eight limbs, not the purusharthas.
- [Q29-D] Wrong: this is the textual-commentary chain (root text to sub-commentary), not the goals of life.

Examiner trap: Candidates state all four purusharthas as if they were coined together from the start, missing the historically layered addition of moksha.

MCQ 30 - Q30

In the routed 2022 Prelims scholar-identification demand, Dignaga is correctly identified as:

A. a Jaina scholar associated with the Agamas. B. a Buddhist scholar and logician associated with the Madhyamaka-adjacent scholastic and logical tradition. C. a Vaishnava scholar who collected the Alvar hymns. D. a Mimamsa ritual commentator.

Answer: B. Dignaga is a Buddhist logician central to the development of formal Buddhist epistemology.

- [Q30-A] Wrong: Dignaga is not a Jaina figure; Aryadeva is the Buddhist thinker sometimes mismatched with Jainism in this routed item.
- [Q30-B] Correct: Dignaga is a Buddhist logician central to the development of formal Buddhist epistemology.
- [Q30-C] Wrong: Nathamuni, not Dignaga, is the Vaishnava scholar linked to the Alvar hymns.
- [Q30-D] Wrong: Dignaga has no connection to Mimamsa ritual commentary.

Examiner trap: Candidates confuse the three named scholars (Aryadeva, Dignaga, Nathamuni) in this routed item because they appear together in one matching-style demand.

MCQ 31 - Q31

In the same routed demand, Nathamuni is correctly identified as:

A. a Buddhist logician. B. an Ajivika ascetic. C. a Vaishnava scholar associated with collecting the Alvar hymns into the Nalayira Divya Prabandham. D. the author of the Aihole inscription.

Answer: C. Nathamuni is linked to compiling the Alvar hymn collection within the Vaishnava bhakti tradition.

- [Q31-A] Wrong: Dignaga, not Nathamuni, is the Buddhist logician in this routed demand.
- [Q31-B] Wrong: no Ajivika connection is attributed to Nathamuni in the verified route.
- [Q31-C] Correct: Nathamuni is linked to compiling the Alvar hymn collection within the Vaishnava bhakti tradition.
- [Q31-D] Wrong: the Aihole inscription belongs to a different topic (Chalukya court poetry), unconnected to Nathamuni.

Examiner trap: Candidates who correctly identify Dignaga sometimes then guess wildly for Nathamuni instead of applying the same source-by-source discipline.

MCQ 32 - Q32

Which correction best repairs the claim "the best GS-I answer on ancient Indian philosophy is simply a list of the six schools"?

A. The best answer lists only socio-economic background with no doctrinal content. B. The best answer gives only a spiritual conclusion with no evidence. C. The best answer names every school without explaining what problem each was answering. D. The best answer follows chronology, defines core concepts, compares schools, states source-critical limits, and closes with a bounded verdict on ancient India's plural argumentative civilisation.

Answer: D. Chronology, concepts, comparison, source caution and a bounded verdict together form the taught answer architecture.

- [Q32-A] Wrong: background alone omits the doctrinal comparison an examiner expects.
- [Q32-B] Wrong: an unevidenced spiritual conclusion earns no analytical marks.
- [Q32-C] Wrong: a bare school list without explaining the problem each school answers is exactly the shallow answer this package corrects.
- [Q32-D] Correct: chronology, concepts, comparison, source caution and a bounded verdict together form the taught answer architecture.

Examiner trap: Candidates under time pressure default to a memorised school-name list instead of the fuller chronology-to-verdict architecture that actually scores well.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved topic-specific MCQs

> Objective answers without a secure local official key are labelled inferred, translated or adjacent exactly as required.

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims GS-I 2024 Q58 (exact wording locally preserved)

Consider the statements:

1. There are no parables in Upanishads.
2. Upanishads were composed earlier than the Puranas.

Which statement(s) is/are correct?

Status: Official local Set-A question paper and official Series-A answer key were already validated in Topic 09. Official answer: **B, statement 2 only**.

Explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because early Upanishads teach through dialogues, stories, analogies and paradoxes. Uddalaka's teaching to Shvetaketu is a standard narrative-analogy anchor. Statement 2 is correct because the early Upanishadic corpus belongs to the later Vedic / early first-millennium BCE horizon, whereas the Puranas were compiled and expanded much later over long centuries. [LIMIT] Exact dates of individual Upanishads and Puranic layers remain debated, but the relative chronology tested here is secure.

Why this earns marks: It answers at the level of both statement logic and source chronology, which is exactly what the Prelims trap is testing.

Demand decoding: This is a two-statement objective item: each statement must be checked independently as true or false against the Upanishads' actual teaching method and relative chronology before the two verdicts are combined into one of the four standard combination options; it is a verification task, not a free-form analytical one.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Test statement 1 against the Upanishads' dialogic/parabolic teaching style (Yajnavalkya's exposition, Uddalaka's instruction to Shvetaketu); test statement 2 against the relative chronology of the early Upanishadic corpus versus later Puranic compilation; select the option that keeps only statement 2.

How to improve this answer: Name one additional specific parable, such as Uddalaka's "salt dissolved in water" analogy, so the rebuttal of statement 1 is anchored to a checkable textual example rather than a general claim about "dialogue."

Routed PYQ 2 - Prelims GS-I 2022 Q56 (faithful English rendering from locally preserved Hindi paper; official key unavailable locally)

Consider the following pairs:

1. Aryadeva - Jaina scholar
2. Dignaga - Buddhist scholar
3. Nathamuni - Vaishnava scholar

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

Status: The local official paper page is preserved and was visually checked, but the accessible preserved question page is Hindi. The rendering above is faithful in content, not claimed as locally verified official English wording. No official local answer key is held.

Answer / route: Only two pairs are correct.

- Aryadeva is not a Jaina scholar in this route; he is a Buddhist thinker associated with the Madhyamaka tradition.
- Dignaga is correctly identified as a Buddhist scholar and later logician.
- Nathamuni is correctly identified as a Vaishnava scholar associated with collecting the Alvar hymns into the Nalayira Divya Prabandham.

Why this earns marks: It solves the exact conceptual demand honestly without inventing a missing official key or pretending that the English wording was locally preserved when it was not.

Demand decoding: This is a three-pair matching item: each named scholar (Aryadeva, Dignaga, Nathamuni) must be checked independently against his correct school or tradition, and the demand is a count of correctly matched pairs, not a judgement on the passage as a whole.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Verify Aryadeva against Buddhist Madhyamaka (not Jaina, the tempting mismatch); verify Dignaga against the Buddhist logical tradition; verify Nathamuni against the Vaishnava bhakti tradition; count two correct pairs and select "only two."

How to improve this answer: Name the Nalayira Divya Prabandham explicitly as Nathamuni's compilation, so the Vaishnava identification is anchored to a specific text rather than a bare label.

Adjacent PYQ 3 - GS-I Mains 2020 Q11 (adjacent owner route, verbatim demand preserved in Art and Culture owner)

Indian philosophy and tradition played a significant role in conceiving and shaping the monuments and their art in India. Discuss. (250 words)

Status: This demand is owner-routed to Indian Art and Culture Topic 13, not to Topic 24. It is included here because a student preparing Topic 24 should still understand how philosophical concepts move outward into artistic form without collapsing art history into pure doctrine.

Model answer: Indian monuments and art were not mechanically "designed by philosophy," but philosophical traditions strongly shaped their symbolic programmes, ritual use and visual logic. Buddhist ideas of relic veneration, sacred presence and the path generated the stupa form, circumambulation and narrative reliefs. Jaina ideals of renunciation, tirthankara veneration and ordered cosmology informed cave shrines and later iconographic discipline. Brahmanical and Upanishadic-Vedantic currents shaped temple iconography through cosmic ordering, sacred axis, image as embodied divinity and the integration of dharma, artha, kama and moksha within sacred space. Bhakti and sectarian theology later deepened this logic through Shaiva and Vaishnava image programmes. Yet philosophy was never the sole cause: patronage, craft skill, materials, regional politics and donor communities also mattered. Indian philosophy and tradition therefore shaped monument conception most strongly at the level of sacred meaning, symbolic programme and ritual use, while actual built form emerged through interaction with society, patronage and technology.

Why this earns marks: It links concept to monument without making the false claim that one doctrine mechanically "produced" one form.

Verified format: UPSC GS-I Mains 2020 Q11 is a 15-mark question with a 250-word limit under the directive **discuss**, as confirmed against the locally held 2020 GS-I paper; this package retains that exact marks/word-limit pairing rather than substituting a generic value.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires presenting how philosophy shaped monuments across more than one tradition (Buddhist, Jain, Brahmanical-Vedantic, bhakti-sectarian) while also weighing the non-philosophical causes (patronage, craft, materials, politics) that the demand implicitly invites a candidate to test against, not a single-line assertion that "philosophy shaped art."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 15-mark, 250-word answer, open with a two-sentence thesis distinguishing symbolic shaping from mechanical causation; cover four named tradition-to-form links (stupa/circumambulation, cave shrines, temple iconography, bhakti image programmes) as evidence units; close with the patronage/craft/politics qualification and a bounded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name one specific monument per tradition (for example Sanchi for the stupa form, Ellora or Elephanta for cave shrines, and a named temple such as Khajuraho or the Lingaraja temple) so each evidence unit is anchored to a checkable site rather than a general category.

Original Mains Question 1 - 10 marks - 150 words

How did early Upanishadic speculation transform the meaning of Vedic ritual without simply rejecting the Vedic world?

Model answer: Early Upanishadic thought transformed rather than simply discarded the Vedic world. The Brahmanas and Aranyakas had already begun symbolic interpretation of sacrifice; the early Upanishads pushed this further by shifting prestige toward knowledge of brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and release. Dialogues such as Yajnavalkya's and the teaching of Uddalaka to Shvetaketu show that inner knowledge, not only outer performance, became central. Ritual language was re-read rather than erased: sacrifice became interiorised, equivalence-seeking and philosophically charged. This was not a total break. The Upanishads remain within shruti, and they do not uniformly denounce Vedic ritual. The transformation therefore lies in redirection of authority from external efficacy alone toward reflective knowing and liberation while preserving continuity with the Vedic textual world.

Why this earns marks: It gives continuity plus change, names the transition texts and avoids the simplistic "anti-Vedic revolt" line.

Demand decoding: The implicit directive is **explain**: "how did X transform Y" requires the mechanism of change (continuity plus redirection), not merely an assertion that a transformation occurred.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 10-mark, 150-word answer, open with a one-sentence thesis on redirection of authority from ritual efficacy to knowledge; name three evidence units (Brahmana/Aranyaka symbolic groundwork, the Yajnavalkya and Uddalaka-Shvetaketu dialogues, the shruti-continuity limit); close with the "redirection, not rejection" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Name the Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya Upanishads explicitly as the source texts for the cited dialogues, so each evidence unit is anchored to a specific work rather than "the Upanishads" in general.

Original Mains Question 2 - 10 marks - 150 words

Why must Ajivikas and Charvakas be studied with stronger source criticism than Buddhism or Nyaya?

Model answer: Ajivikas and Charvakas require stronger source criticism because their internal archives survive far more poorly than those of Buddhism, Jainism, Nyaya or Mimamsa. Ajivikas are known largely through hostile Buddhist and Jaina accounts, with rare hard anchors such as Mauryan cave patronage and the doctrine of niyati. Charvaka or Lokayata is preserved mostly through later doxographies and rival refutations, not through a secure foundational text. This means historians often know these schools through the language of opponents, who may caricature determinism, hedonism or anti-ritual critique. Source-poverty does not make the schools unreal. It simply lowers the confidence with which details should be stated. Strong source criticism is therefore part of the actual content of these traditions, not an external methodological extra.

Why this earns marks: It explains not only that evidence is thin, but why that changes the form of historical judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **justify** requires giving the specific evidentiary reason (differential source survival and hostile transmission) rather than a general claim that "the evidence is old."

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 10-mark, 150-word answer, open with a one-sentence thesis on unequal source survival; name three evidence units (hostile Buddhist/Jaina testimony on the Ajivikas, Charvaka's transmission through doxography rather than a founding text, the resulting caricature risk); close with the verdict that source criticism is part of the content, not an external add-on.

How to improve this answer: Name Barabar-Nagarjuni cave patronage explicitly as the one surviving material anchor for the Ajivikas, balancing the textual-absence argument with a concrete counter-example.

Original Mains Question 3 - 15 marks - 250 words

Discuss how the shramana challenge reshaped the intellectual field of ancient India without being reducible to urbanisation alone.

Model answer: The shramana challenge reshaped ancient Indian thought by relocating debate from sacrificial centrality toward suffering, bondage, discipline, karma, selfhood and liberation, but this shift cannot be reduced to a simple by-product of urban growth. Buddhism recast the human problem through dependent origination, impermanence and non-self. Jainism developed a rigorous soul-karmic bondage model alongside anekantavada and syadvada. Ajivikas were remembered for niyati, while materialist currents challenged scriptural and afterlife claims. These traditions flourished in a wider world of towns, trade routes, kings, gana-sanghas and patronage, which made itinerant debate and renouncer communities more viable. Urbanisation mattered because it widened audiences, donors and social mobility. Yet doctrines were not mechanically caused by commerce. Buddhist non-self, Jaina karmic materialism and Ajivika determinism are conceptually distinct responses to shared existential and social pressures. Nor did the shramana field annihilate the Vedic world; Mimamsa and Vedanta show strong Brahmanical philosophical continuities. The shramana challenge is therefore best understood as an argumentative reconfiguration of ancient Indian thought within a changing social landscape, not as an economic reflex.

Why this earns marks: It combines context and doctrine, gives named evidence from multiple traditions and closes with a balanced causal qualification.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires balancing the shramana challenge's doctrinal content against its urbanisation context, explicitly rejecting a monocausal economic explanation while still crediting context as enabling.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 15-mark, 250-word answer, open with a two-sentence thesis separating enabling context from doctrinal cause; name five evidence units (Buddhism's non-self, Jainism's karmic bondage, Ajivika niyati, materialist critique, urban/patronage context); close with the Mimamsa/Vedanta continuity qualification and a bounded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one named example of the urban/trade setting (such as a specific gana-sangha capital or trade route town) so the urbanisation claim is concrete rather than a background generalisation.

Original Mains Question 4 - 15 marks - 250 words

Compare Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa and Vedanta as distinct answers to knowledge, world and authority.

Model answer: These four schools answer different leading questions, which is why grouping them all as "orthodox philosophy" hides their real intellectual diversity. Nyaya asks how truth-claims are established through pramanas such as perception, inference, comparison and testimony; its five-member inference turns proof into public method. Vaisheshika asks what kinds of things exist and builds a realist ontology through padarthas and atomism. Mimamsa treats Vedic injunction, dharma and ritual interpretation as the core problem, turning hermeneutics into philosophy. Vedanta re-centres inquiry on the Upanishads, brahman, atman and the Brahma Sutra, trying to synthesise a metaphysical-exegetical field. Thus Nyaya privileges epistemic procedure, Vaisheshika ontological categories, Mimamsa textual-action authority and Vedanta ultimate reality through scripture. Later histories pair Nyaya with Vaisheshika and Mimamsa with Vedanta, but the pairings should not erase their distinct original emphases. The comparison shows that ancient Indian philosophy was not one doctrinal bloc; even within the so-called orthodox field, proof, world, duty and ultimate reality were separately and rigorously argued.

Why this earns marks: It compares by problem-type rather than by memorised label and therefore produces analytical depth quickly.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires matching each school to the specific problem it answers (proof, ontology, ritual authority, ultimate reality) rather than listing four definitions in isolation.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 15-mark, 250-word answer, open with a two-sentence thesis on differing leading questions; name four evidence units (Nyaya's pramanas and five-member inference, Vaisheshika's padarthas, Mimamsa's vidhi-hermeneutics, Vedanta's Upanishadic-Brahma Sutra synthesis); close with the later-pairing qualification and a verdict on real intellectual diversity within the "orthodox" label.

How to improve this answer: Name the founding sutra text for each school (Nyaya Sutra, Vaisheshika Sutra, Mimamsa Sutra, Brahma Sutra) so the comparison is textually anchored rather than only conceptual.

Original Mains Question 5 - 20 marks - 250 words

Ancient Indian philosophy was a plural argumentative field rather than a single spiritual consensus. Examine.

Model answer: Ancient Indian philosophy was indeed plural and argumentative; describing it as one spiritual consensus erases the very debates that made the tradition historically powerful. The Upanishads shifted authority toward self-knowledge and liberation but did so in internally diverse ways. Buddhism denied a permanent self and explained existence through dependent origination. Jainism defended real souls, karmic bondage and many-sided knowing. Ajivikas were remembered for niyati, while Charvaka challenged Vedic authority and unseen metaphysical claims. Among the astika schools, Samkhya offered purusha-prakriti dualism, Yoga disciplined mind toward release, Nyaya built public reasoning, Vaisheshika classified being, Mimamsa defended ritual-hermeneutic authority and Vedanta systematised Upanishadic metaphysics. These are not variations of one identical spiritual message. They disagree about self, causation, proof, scripture and liberation. Yet the field is not chaotic: debate, commentary and institutions created shared argumentative rules. "Plural" does not mean every school was equally preserved; doxography and hostile sources create distortions. Ancient Indian philosophy is therefore best described as an argumentative civilisation in which rivalry, borrowing and commentary produced long-lived intellectual plurality.

Why this earns marks: It uses range without becoming a list, and it ties plurality to actual points of doctrinal disagreement plus institutional form.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires testing the "plural argumentative field" claim against named counter-positions from across the astika/nastika spectrum, rather than merely asserting plurality.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 20-mark, 250-word answer, open with a two-sentence thesis rejecting "one spiritual consensus"; name seven evidence units spanning the Upanishads, Buddhism, Jainism, the Ajivikas, Charvaka and the six astika schools; close with the doxography/hostile-source qualification and a verdict describing an argumentative civilisation.

How to improve this answer: Add one named cross-school debate or refutation (for example a Buddhist logician's critique of a Nyaya position) to show argumentative interaction rather than a parallel list of schools.

Original Mains Question 6 - 20 marks - 250 words

Trace the movement from late Vedic speculation to classical darshana systematisation, bringing out both continuity and rupture.

Model answer: The movement from late Vedic speculation to classical darshana systematisation involved both continuity of vocabulary and rupture in emphasis, method and institutional location. Vedic and later Vedic texts supplied categories such as rta, sacrifice, sacred speech and speculative questioning. Aranyakas and early Upanishads interiorised ritual and developed brahman, atman, karma, rebirth and moksha through dialogue and paradox. The shramana field then radicalised the debate: Buddhism reframed bondage through non-self and conditioned arising; Jainism through soul and karmic matter; Ajivikas through fate; materialists through perceptual critique. Over time, sutra traditions such as Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, Yoga and the Brahma Sutra compressed and systematised distinctive positions. Grammar, commentary and public disputation deepened the field further. Continuity lies in long concern with order, duty, speech, liberation and knowledge. Rupture lies in new critiques of ritual centrality, sharper school identities and more technical epistemological and metaphysical debate. The process was uneven, and later six-school doxography can falsely tidy it up. Ancient Indian philosophy thus moved from layered speculative beginnings to increasingly explicit schools without ever losing the marks of cumulative borrowing and contest.

Why this earns marks: It is chronological, comparative and source-aware, which is exactly what a long GS-I answer on this topic requires.

Workbook closing recap

- Start long answers with chronology, not with an isolated school list.
- Keep Vedic, Upanishadic, shramana and sutra phases distinct.
- Use at least one named thinker or text if time permits.
- Treat astika / nastika as historical classifications, not as theist / atheist labels.
- Use Ajivika and Charvaka with stronger source caution.
- Do not project later Vedanta backward into the earliest Upanishads.
- For comparison answers, organise by self, causation, pramana and liberation-path.
- For 2024 Q58, remember both parts: Upanishadic parables exist, and early Upanishads predate the Puranic world.
- For 2022 Q56, remember the pairing triangle: Aryadeva and Dignaga are Buddhist; Nathamuni is Vaishnava.
- End with plural argumentative civilisation, not with spiritual homogenisation.

Demand decoding: The directive **trace**, combined with "bringing out both continuity and rupture," requires a chronological sequence from late Vedic speculation to classical darshana systematisation while explicitly separating what continues (vocabulary, concern with order and liberation) from what changes (ritual centrality, sharper school identity, technical debate).

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For this 20-mark, 250-word answer, open with a two-sentence thesis on continuity-plus-rupture; name six evidence units in chronological order (Vedic categories, Aranyaka/Upanishadic interiorisation, shramana doctrines, sutra systematisation, grammar/commentary, public disputation); close with the caution against a falsely tidy six-school doxography and a bounded verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit date-range marker per phase (for example "mid-first-millennium BCE" for the shramana phase) to sharpen the chronological trace an examiner rewards.